

THE GREAT TRANSFORMATION

Many of the fundamental categories of twentieth-century psychology are, to all intents and purposes, twentieth-century inventions. Such concepts as 'intelligence', 'personality', 'behaviour' and 'learning' were given such radically changed meanings by modern psychology that there simply are no earlier equivalents. In other cases, for example 'motivation' or 'social attitudes', the use of the terms themselves was new, describing previously unsuspected phenomenal domains. The coming of modern psychology was associated with a revolutionary restructuring of the network of categories employed in the conceptualization of human experience and conduct.

But not everything was changed. Certain, unquestionably psychological, categories were retained with little or no change in meaning from an earlier period. Concepts like 'emotion', 'motive' (which is not 'motivation'), 'consciousness' or 'self-esteem' made the transition to the modern period without any radical change in meaning. The existence of this more venerable group points to an older layer of psychological concepts that antedated the emergence of Psychology as a discipline. Of course, this older layer also contained such prominent categories as 'will' and 'character' which did not survive the transition to a scientific psychology. Why then did one group survive and another not?

The answer proposed here is that the survivors were part of a categorical network whose basic features were bequeathed to modern psychology by an earlier period. To use an archaeological analogy: in constructing its domain, modern Psychology used building blocks from older settlements insofar as these were still serviceable under the new conditions. However, the image of building blocks is perhaps misleading. It would be more appropriate to speak of foundations. For it was not a pile of disconnected conceptual units that was taken over but a lattice of interconnected parts. In the present chapter we will describe some of the historical roots of these foundations.

Eighteenth-century novelties

If we try to trace back the meaning of the older psychological categories that are still in systematic use today we quickly lose the trail once we go

back further than the eighteenth century. Unless we are determined to see modern meanings where none exist, and to close our eyes to crucial distinctions, we will find ourselves in quite unfamiliar conceptual territory, even in the seventeenth century. True, there will be occasional flashes of recognition evoked by this or that element, but these elements will usually be embedded in an alien framework and will not be historically continuous with their later incarnations.¹ For example, in the previous chapter we noted the essentially traditional nature of Descartes' ideas about the 'passions'. Between these ideas and later concepts of 'emotion' or 'motivation' there is a vast conceptual gulf. We cannot travel from one to the other without entering an entirely different landscape.

The very notion of 'Psychology' does not exist before the eighteenth century. Of course, there was no lack of reflection about human experience and conduct, but to imagine that all such reflection was 'psychological' in our sense is to project the present on to the past. Before the eighteenth century there was no sense of a distinct and identifiable domain of natural phenomena that could be systematically known and characterized as 'psychological'. There were theological, philosophical, moral, rhetorical, medical, aesthetic, political categories, but no psychological categories.

When these made their appearance in the eighteenth century the need for a specific label gradually made itself felt. That label was invented in Germany towards the middle of the century and later travelled to France (Dessoir, 1902; Pongratz, 1967; Scheerer, 1989). Before this time, 'Psychology' crops up occasionally in reference to knowledge about spiritual creatures (Lapointe, 1972). It is only from the second half of the eighteenth century that there exists a continuous discursive domain under that label. In Britain, such a domain had emerged at about the same time, but it had come to be known as mental philosophy. Only towards the middle of the nineteenth century did the lexically more convenient 'Psychology' begin to be adopted (Hamilton, 1863).

It was in its British form that eighteenth century psychology survived in the twentieth century. There are two major reasons for this. One has to do with the historical accident that twentieth-century psychology came to be dominated by one national psychological tradition, the American, that was in direct line of descent from British mental and moral philosophy. Early modern American Psychology took many of its categories from nineteenth-century British textbooks, which had inherited those categories, with little fundamental change, from an earlier generation of British texts.² In many cases those categories were part of everyday English usage.

A second, and more fundamental, reason for the long term survival of certain psychological categories from eighteenth-century British philosophy lies in their appropriateness to conditions of life that have undergone little essential change during the intervening period. In certain fundamental respects eighteenth-century Britain was the first

major example of a modern society. It was characterized by a new social order, based on free wage labour and capital, the ubiquity of commercial and contractual relationships, the principle of representative government, individual enterprise, and scientific rationality. Under these conditions the old moral discourse began to lose its force and relevance. A new moral discourse, more in tune with the times, derived its principles from knowledge about what was now called *human nature*, not from revealed truth or rational deduction from metaphysical certainties. A new set of categories was developed for the description of this human nature, which, one is not surprised to discover, would have been rather well adapted to life as a man of property in eighteenth-century Britain. These new categories involved a fundamental reconstruction of ancient conceptions about both reason and the passions, and some of the products of that reconstruction were to prove remarkably durable.

The construction of a new moral discourse involves a complex historical process. Over a relatively long period, countless individuals increasingly encounter situations in which old ways of making sense no longer work. Quite unintentionally, and usually without awareness, subtle changes creep into the way words are used, new terms appear and novel perspectives emerge. Sooner or later, these changes are reflected in written texts which later provide historians with their raw material. Such texts will belong to a variety of genres – literary, medical and scientific, educational, philosophical, and so on. In principle, material from any and all of these genres is relevant for the reconstruction of the historical process.

Nevertheless, the present chapter is limited to a consideration of texts that can be described as ‘philosophical’ in character. There are several reasons for this restriction, the first being economical. To trace all facets of the kind of transformation that is of interest here would require a lifetime of work from many scholars. In this chapter, however, the aim is only to pick out certain themes that are directly linked to later developments in psychology. No doubt one could point to innumerable indirect links, if one looked for them. But, because of the way in which the discipline of Psychology arose, the direct links mostly involve philosophical texts and writings in the medical-biological domain. The latter will be explored in the next chapter. For the present, we will concentrate on the philosophical genre. This genre is also particularly useful in pursuing our general goal of tracing the historical construction of psychological categories. Philosophical texts strive for conceptual clarification, and in doing so they often systematize and make explicit what is left indistinct by other writers. Such texts also tend to address matters that are taken for granted elsewhere and therefore provide valuable insights into the process of category construction. Relying on these useful features of the philosophical genre does not, however, mean that philosophers are assumed to be the individual creators of the changes that their publications allow one to document.

From passion to emotion

In the first place, the fundamentally changed social circumstances had made it imperative to re-evaluate the passions. So far from being undesirable, a certain kind of passion seemed in fact to be necessary for the success of the kind of society that had now emerged. This insight was provocatively presented in the form of a fable for the times that caused an enormous commotion. It was called *The Fable of the Bees*, and it bore the telling subtitle: *Private Vices, Publick Benefits* (Kaye, 1924). Its author, Bernard de Mandeville, a Dutch physician who had settled in London, had summed up a current dilemma by telling of a great and prosperous hive of bees who were upset by the fact that vices like pride, envy and vanity were so widespread among them. But when a higher power turned them all into virtuous and honest individuals, the hive quickly lost both its greatness and its prosperity. Two essays appended to the fable's second edition in 1723 drove home the moral: public benefits result from private vices.

The fable released a veritable flood of responses. By 1759, no fewer than 145 of these had appeared (Kaye, 1924), an extraordinary result for the time and a clear indication that its author had struck an exposed nerve. Among the critics were several of Britain's foremost philosophers, and the influence of the fable was still important half a century later.³ One of the philosophers who responded to the challenge of the fable in terms that are especially relevant to the reconceptualization of the passions was Francis Hutcheson, Adam Smith's teacher. He made a distinction between 'calm' desires that led to the pursuit of very general goals, like wealth and power, and more specific affections of the mind which were often linked to 'confused sensations' and 'violent bodily motions' (Hutcheson, 1969). Only the latter were true passions, while it was the former which constituted the private origin of 'public benefits'.

A similar move had been made just two years earlier by Bishop Butler, who was then a much respected authority on questions of moral philosophy. Butler thought there was a big difference between 'cool or settled selfishness' and 'passionate or sensual selfishness' (Butler, 1950: 13). It was only the latter which was to be condemned, while the former was quite beneficial, both to the individual and to society. There were really two kinds of motivated action. The first kind involved specific impulses directed at particular objects, without regard to the ultimate consequences for the individual. The second kind constituted what Butler called 'an interested action'.⁴ Such actions were governed by 'the cool principle of self-love or general desire of our happiness and private good' (1950: 52). This distinction was not merely a convenient device for purposes of classification; it was thought to correspond to fundamental elements of human nature. Therefore, much of the conflict previously seen in terms of the war between reason and the passions was now

accounted for in terms of the clash between sensuality and 'self-love' or 'interest'.

The distinction between two classes of non-rational affections of the soul followed the general scheme of the empiricist philosophy as laid down by John Locke. According to this scheme, mental contents were to be divided into one category that was the product of direct sensory experience and another category that constituted the results of mental reflection on this sensory basis. Locke had been primarily concerned with epistemological questions. The eighteenth-century moral philosophers devoted more attention to the operation of Locke's distinction in the field of conduct and its regulation. Here a parallel distinction had to be made between those impulses to action that affected the mind directly through the senses (internal as well as external) and those that were the result of reflection. The former constituted the 'violent' passions, while the latter took the form of 'calm', 'cool' or 'gentle' passions or interests. These were thought of as being gradually formed in the course of individual development, as the result of reflection on past actions and their outcomes. It was by learning from their personal experience that individuals developed an active concern for their general self-interest.

Not many years after Butler and Hutcheson had driven a deep wedge between two kinds of passion, David Hume, a more profound and ultimately more influential philosopher, adopted a similar distinction between what he referred to as *calm* and *violent* passions. However, he adds a clarification which shifts the basis for the distinction. He will not be concerned, he says, with the immediate effects of pure sensory impressions, only with 'reflective impressions', that is, those which are already affected by past experience (Hume, 1978: 276). That means the distinction between 'calm' and 'gentle' passions cannot be traced to the Lockean distinction between sensation and reflection (Ardal, 1966). What then is to be the new basis for distinguishing among the passions?

A clue to the answer is provided by Hume's frequent use of a word which hardly figured at all in previous discussions of the topic. That word is *emotion*. It was a fairly recent derivative of *motion* that had been used to describe either a physical or a social agitation. By analogy, it was also applied to mental agitation or excitement. But at this point it lacked any kind of systematic status, being no more than a slightly picturesque descriptive term. That is still how Hume uses it, but the context in which he employs it gives it a fresh prominence. On the surface, the context is provided by a further development of the distinction between calm and violent passion. Hume argues that this distinction conflates two characteristics which should be kept distinct: the present violence with which a passion manifests itself, and the strength of the passion as a motive for action:

Men often counter-act a violent passion in prosecution of their interests and designs: 'Tis not therefore the present uneasiness alone, which determines them. In general we may observe, that both these principles operate on the

will; and where they are contrary, that either of them prevails, according to the *general* character or present *disposition* of the person. . . . 'Tis evident passions influence not the will in proportion to their violence, or the disorder they occasion in the temper; but on the contrary, that when a passion has once become a settled principle of action, and is the predominant inclination of the soul, it commonly produces no longer any sensible agitation . . . it directs the actions and conduct without that opposition and emotion, which so naturally attended every momentary gust of passion. We must, therefore, distinguish betwixt a calm and a weak passion; betwixt a violent and a strong one. (Hume, 1978: 418-419)

Here there emerges in outline a distinction that has become quite familiar to us, but that had remained nebulous in the writings of Hume's predecessors – the distinction between a motive and an emotion. Hume still talks of passions, but that category is now seen as mixing up several different things: it mixes up temporary states and settled dispositions, and it mixes up motive causes (which vary in strength) and mental agitations (which vary in intensity). As Hume's point of view came to be shared by more and more people, these distinctions were seen as much more significant than the old distinction between reason and the passions. Eventually, that resulted in the demise of 'the passions' as a category of scientific discourse and its replacement by *emotion*. But because the passions had such a weighty historical tradition behind them and were deeply embedded in ordinary usage, that took some time. The process was not complete until the second half of the nineteenth century.

In the meantime, people wrestled with the co-existence of the old and the new terminology. Initially, the distinction between motive cause and mental agitation was suggested as a basis for discriminating among passions and emotions. In 1762, Henry Home (better known as Lord Kames) addressed this question:

Are passion and emotion synonymous terms? This cannot be averred. No feeling nor agitation of the mind devoid of desire, is termed a passion; and we have discovered that there are many emotions which pass away without raising desire of any kind. . . . An internal motion or agitation of the mind, when it passeth away without raising desire, is denominated an emotion: when desire is raised, the motion or agitation is denominated a passion. (Kames, 1970: 53-54)

Note how passion is no longer a fundamental category. The basic categories are emotion and desire, and passion is now merely the name for their combination.

By the early nineteenth century, there was at least one influential system of mental philosophy in which the term 'emotion' had advanced to being the name for all non-intellectual states of mind. In Thomas Brown's system the passions no longer have a place. Instead, he is able to rely on the secure position which 'emotion' had by then achieved in everyday understanding: 'Every person understands what is meant by an *emotion*,' he tells his audience, when he introduces his basic distinction

between intellectual and non-intellectual states of mind, the latter being referred to as emotions (Brown, 1831, I: 165).⁵ In this scheme there are three categories of emotion, the immediate (example: admiration), the prospective (example: hope), and the retrospective (example: remorse). By and large, desires are classified as prospective emotions. Although Brown's promiscuous use of the term 'emotion' was unusual, the category was now well established. It continued to be evoked throughout the nineteenth century in reference to a major class of psychological objects.

There is a context for the rise of 'emotion' that should not be overlooked. If Hume made the distinctions he did, it was not just because he was a very bright fellow, which he undoubtedly was. There was a change of perspective, a change of world view, that formed the background for his originality. And if the opposition between reason and the passions seemed in the end to lose its hold, this was not just because of the fractionation of the passions; the other side of the polarity, reason, was presumably also implicated. The conceptual change that created the modern concepts of motivation and emotion involved much more than one or two specific distinctions. Important though these were, they were made possible by a rearrangement of a whole network of concepts covering the explanation of human action.

Instrumental reason

So far, we have concentrated on the passions, but it is obvious that no one could have believed in any effective opposition between reason and passion unless they assumed reason to have some kind of causal power. Individuals sometimes acted under the influence of passion, but that influence could be counteracted by the force of reason. Virtually everyone took this for granted right up to the end of the seventeenth century.

But then the fortress of reason began to crumble. An early breach was made by Francis Hutcheson. It seemed to him that when we ask for the reasons of an action the answer may be either in terms of the real causes of the action or in terms of what makes the action 'reasonable' or worthy of approval or disapproval. The two are not the same. If someone is asked why he joined the army he may offer good patriotic reasons, but the actual causes of his action may be far less exalted: being broke or running away from home, perhaps. Thus, Hutcheson (1969: 217ff.) distinguishes between 'exciting' and 'justifying' reasons. The latter are rational propositions, which, according to Hutcheson, never moved anyone to action. That power belongs to the affections or passions, for only they can function as *motives*. He uses a telling analogy: 'Rhubarb strengthens the stomach,' we say. That proposition may justify our fondness for rhubarb, but it cannot strengthen the stomach – only the natural action of the rhubarb can do that.

The dethronement of reason is completed by Hume. What had been a useful distinction for Hutcheson now becomes an absolute principle governing the explanation of human conduct: 'reason alone can never be a motive to any action of the will . . . it can never oppose passion in the direction of the will' (Hume, 1978: 413). Behind such confident pronouncements lies a revolutionary recasting of the entire network of basic categories used to make human action intelligible. Hume still uses traditional terms, like 'passion', 'will' and 'reason', but they no longer mean what they used to mean. We have already seen how 'passion' had become morally neutered to include any 'calm' and 'settled' disposition capable of acting as a motive. Concomitant changes in 'will' and 'reason' were even more profound.

What had held the concept of the passions in place over the centuries was the polarity between them and reason. The passions were what they were by virtue of their opposition to reason. But reason, it must be remembered, was not simply an individual attribute (see Chapter 2). Rather, it was the individual's link with the universal. From the necessity of the laws of reason flowed the order of values that governed the human world. This order was fixed and objective, though individuals could be deficient in their understanding of it. By the High Middle Ages individuals were thought to be endowed with a rational will that enabled them to participate voluntarily in the higher order of the cosmos by controlling their passions. Will and reason were conjoined. While the passions were the home of individual, increasingly material, particularity, the rational will opened the door to the eternal moral order of the universe.

All that was now gone. The eighteenth-century moral philosophers all worked in the shadow of Newton, none more so than David Hume. It was established that the order of the universe was mathematical and mechanical. Many still attached deep moral significance to this order, including Newton himself and Bishop Butler, but the conclusions they drew from this were not the traditional ones. Butler (1950), for example, considered the private experience of pleasure and pain to be a reliable moral guide, for God had affixed pleasures and pains to various courses of action in such a way as to make good actions more likely and bad actions less likely, on the whole. It is not through their reason that individuals share in the divine order of the universe, but through their private and sensuous experience of pleasure and pain.

This process of privatization soon affects reason itself. Hutcheson discovers that when persons act under the influence of what have now been identified as 'calm' desires they follow certain 'maxims' or 'natural Laws'. The good or evil to be expected from the objects of such desire is found to be quantifiable, because it is proportional to the duration and intensity of the pleasures and pains afforded by the objects. Hutcheson (1969: 41) also observes that 'men content themselves in all Affairs with smaller, but more probably successful Pursuits, quitting those of greater

Moment but less probability.' If they now multiply this probability by the net quantity of expected pleasure they will arrive at an estimate of the relative desirability of the object. Where there are both positive and negative aspects associated with the attainment of an object, the estimated value of the one is subtracted from the other in order to arrive at the final outcome measure. This is reasoning all right, but what a difference to the reason that was involved in the exercise of the rational will! When operating in the service of the new category of 'calm' desires reason becomes an exercise in calculation (see Brooks and Aalto, 1981). No longer does it lead to the discovery of an objective order of universally binding truths. It has now become *instrumental*, employed in the service of calm desire. From being the master it has become the servant.

This reversal is celebrated in Hume's famous dictum that reason is and ought only to be the slave of the passions. Reason can no longer act with the force of will, because the determinants of human conduct are now seen in terms fashioned after Newtonian natural philosophy. Hume was a convinced determinist. Human action, he claimed, resulted from the workings of a mental machinery that followed regular and predictable patterns. There was no difference in principle between causality in the physical sphere and causality in the mental sphere. In both cases causal determination involved merely the regular succession of perceived events. No 'hidden powers' could be made responsible for the regularities presented in experience. On the psychological level this meant the elimination of any concept of human agency. Individuals acted under the influence of their passions, and reason merely calculated the optimum path for this action. By now, Hume had moved too far out for his contemporaries. But two centuries later, such ideas were no longer shocking.

Motives and the contingency of action

The will was now reduced to a vehicle for the transmission of mental impulses to the motor apparatus. Very little could or need be said about it. In fact, if one was to be completely consistent in applying the new scheme, the will was a redundant concept. On the other hand, the category of *motive* acquired a new importance. Because the will could do nothing on its own, it always required a motive to push it into activity. But motives were not reasons. They could no longer be defined in terms of goals chosen by an agent. Instead, they were now conceptualized as elements in a linear chain of cause and effect that linked human experience and human action. Now that the rational will had disappeared, its place was taken by specific elements that all shared the property of causing action. The class of such elements was identified by the label *motives*. The word 'motive' had existed before, but it now acquired a

new, systematic, status in a coherent scheme for the explanation of human conduct. The hallmark of this scheme was its thoroughgoing determinism.⁶ It was Hume's ambition to lay the foundations for a science of human thought and action along the lines of the Newtonian science of nature. In that sense, it is not altogether far-fetched to refer to his 'contribution to behavioral science' (Miller, 1971).

By the middle of the eighteenth century, a new conception of the relationship between human persons and their actions was in the public domain. But the change had been in the making for some time. We have been focusing on the last stages of the change, because it is in these that the nature of the change appears most clearly. However, in the later stages, certain understandings that had been necessary for the occurrence of the change were already taken for granted. To explore these background assumptions we have to step back a bit in time to a period when they were still controversial and therefore under active discussion.

Philosophically, the basis for the changes I have been discussing had been laid by John Locke at the end of the seventeenth century. In 1690 he had announced that 'the will or preference is determined by something without itself' (Locke, 1959: 375), but had still identified this determinant as 'the good'. One might say that he had half broken with the traditional conception. A few years later, his revised text uses a different language: 'The motive for continuing in the same state or action, is only the present satisfaction in it; the motive to change is always some uneasiness' (1959: 331). The determinants of the will, that is of action, no longer have any intrinsic connection with the supra-individual domain of reason or morality; they have a purely individual and private origin in feelings of satisfaction or unease. These latter, also known as pleasures and pains, provide the common attribute of all motives. Whereas in the classical scheme only some actions – those under the influence of the passions – were undertaken for the sake of private satisfaction, now all actions were assumed to be determined in this way.⁷

This privatization of the causes of action was based on a pervasive sense of separation between human agents and their actions. For male members of the propertied classes the new social order had greatly increased the possibilities of personal choice and acting on one's own account. For such persons, at least, considering alternative courses of action in the light of one's personal preferences had become the norm. In the past, one's course of action had generally been prescribed by tradition, by moral rules experienced as universally valid, or by the commands of authorities to whom one was tied by bonds of unquestioning loyalty and obedience. The question of private preference did not arise. For a large but diminishing part of the population that condition continued well into the modern period. But for the privileged strata that provided the producers and consumers of written texts a different experience of action had become more typical. One now felt oneself to

be personally in command of one's own actions, and one could indulge in the luxury of allowing free play to one's private preferences. The link between action and preference was *contingent*: one could choose the action which promised the greatest private benefit in the circumstances.

Locke gave expression to this experience by formulating the relationship between individuals and their actions in terms of *property*. In a very famous passage he states that 'every man has a property in his own person', and in particular in 'the labour of his body and the work of his hands' (Locke, 1980: 19). In other words, my abilities and personal qualities, as well as my actions and their products, are part of me only in the way that my house and my garden are part of me. They may be very dear possessions, but I will deploy them so as to gain the most benefit from them; in other words, I will use them *instrumentally*. Locke's philosophy announces a new way of experiencing the individual's relationship to the world, including his own body and its activity. In this philosophy the property relationship is more fundamental than civil society. In the state of nature, which is imagined as prior to society, individuals already treat parts of the world as their property and devote themselves to accumulating more of it. The actions of an individual constitute his original property and are employed instrumentally to increase his possessions.

Of course, the phenomenon of calculated action had long been known and recognized. But its significance had been minimized in various ways, for example by treating it as a character flaw, or by seeing it as a special skill cultivated by rulers or merchants. The new philosophy, however, asserted that calculated, instrumental action was the 'natural' form of human action in general; it was inherent in 'human nature'. That switch entailed a fundamental reconstruction of the categories used to make human persons and their actions intelligible. Reason became instrumentalized, and the ever more important distinction between 'calm' and 'violent' passion evolved into the difference between motive and emotion.

A new sense of self

The reconstitution of the relationship between individuals and their actions implied changes, not only in the explanation of actions, but also in the conceptualization of the human person. Here too, Locke's work signalled a new era. As late as 1890, William James, in discussing the topic of the 'self', still refers to the 'uproar' caused by Locke's views on this question (James, 1890, I: 349). What exactly was the uproar about? Locke had simply raised the question of personal identity: how do I know that I am now the same person I was yesterday or last year?

Although the question was new, it was obviously both meaningful and unsettling for his audience. It was meaningful because in the

increasingly commercialized society of post-Revolutionary England social identities conferred by birth, such as class, kinship and occupation, were no longer immutable. Not only were individuals becoming separated from their social identities, but that separation was accelerating at a time when the hold of theologically based notions of personal identity was also beginning to weaken. Where neither social identity by descent nor the immortality of the soul provided a sufficient guarantee of permanence and stability, personal identity had to become something that was questionable.

Locke's solution to the problem was to base it on a continuity of consciousness of self. This consciousness of self accompanies all our experiences as a kind of shadow, 'it being impossible for anyone to perceive without *perceiving* that he does perceive'. He explains that 'since consciousness always accompanies thinking, and it is that which makes everyone to be what he calls self, and thereby distinguishes himself from all other thinking beings, in this alone consists personal identity' (Locke, 1959: 449).

This argument depended on the use of two crucial terms in what was then quite a novel manner. The terms were 'consciousness' and 'self'. As regards the former, it seems to have been virtually a neologism whose first recorded occurrence in English hardly antedated Locke's *Essay* (*Oxford English Dictionary*, 1989, III: 756). Locke had invented a means of describing what was then a new way of experiencing the world, that is, separating the sense of self from the experience of one's inner and outer actions. In this world one never just lives or acts; one is always 'conscious' of one's self living and acting.⁸ The self is now a distinct, this-worldly entity, a view which was at first widely regarded as misguided and rather shocking.⁹ Locke's many critics (Fox, 1988) generally reaffirmed the more traditional Christian belief that personal identity depended on an immortal *substance*, the soul. But they were fighting a rearguard action.

Locke had extended into the realm of self-knowledge a radically new way of regarding subject-object relations that had emerged in the seventeenth century. In Chapter 2 we noted how the Aristotelian conception of intellect, or *nous*, depended on an intimate connection between human reason and the rational order of the world. In the modern conception, however, intellect became a purely subjective attribute localized in the minds of individuals and not in the cosmos. In the ancient scheme of things, which persisted with certain modifications through the mediaeval period, it was taken for granted that the same spiritual principles were at work in human individuals and in the world around them. The mediaeval alchemist was convinced that his own inner state was crucial to the outcome of his experiments, an outcome that was not conceived in the crudely material terms that a later age was to impose on them. Pre-modern individuals understood themselves as direct participants in an ambient cosmic order. As this sense of

participation broke down, as individuals became increasingly aware of the depth of the gap between themselves and the world in which they lived, a new conception of the self could become established. The self now became the subjectively localized point of origin from which each individual experienced and acted on a world that had become no more than a source of those experiences and of the raw material for the individual's actions.

The Lockean self has been rather aptly named the *punctual self* (Taylor, 1989), for it is conceived as a point within experience or a focus of concern which is 'disengaged' and quite separate from any specific actions and experiences of the individual. Such a view forms the psychological counterpart to Locke's political doctrines, which were based on a model of society as an aggregate of strictly separate individuals, rather than a collective entity.

In subsequent Anglo-Saxon literature Locke's conception became part of a taken for granted framework for understanding the nature of the self. This conception may be characterized as *empiricist* because the self is regarded as an object that can be empirically known and studied, much like any other object. According to Locke, all knowledge, including self-knowledge, has a sensory origin. Having received some 'ideas' (mental contents) through the senses, the mind 'reflects' on them to form other ideas. In addition, 'it turns its view inward upon itself, and observes its own actions about those ideas it has, takes from thence other ideas, which are as capable to be the objects of its contemplation as any of those it received from foreign things' (Locke, 1959: 159). In other words, one's observation of the contents and the activity of one's own mind is analogous to one's observation of the external world. In the empiricist scheme, the way in which we obtain knowledge about the external world becomes the model for the way in which we are thought to obtain knowledge about ourselves (Toulmin, 1977). What this means is that the cognitive relationship between self-as-subject and self-as-object can, in principle, be just as distanced, and even manipulative, as the relationship between the self and objects that are external to it.

The basis of self-knowledge had been revolutionized. The change in the categories of self-knowledge had affected the representation, not only of the products of such knowledge, but also of the manner in which they were obtained. Invariably, the empiricist mental philosophers back up their knowledge claims by an appeal to a kind of observation that is clearly meant to be as dispassionate as that which the natural philosophers were directing at the external world. Now, however, this dispassionate observation has to be directed *inward* at a world of mental objects waiting to be discovered just like the physical objects of the external world. At its most consistent, this attitude leads to the employment of exactly the same analytic technique for mental observation as had been so successfully used in the case of the physical world. Mental contents were to be dissected into their most elementary

components, and it was these that were regarded as most 'real'. Pursuing this technology to the end, Hume concluded that there was no reality to the self as an entity over and above 'a bundle or collection of different perceptions' (1978: 252).

This was not widely accepted, but in Britain that was not enough to discredit the empiricist approach to the mind. The anti-Humean Scottish School of mental philosophy, founded by Thomas Reid, was just as steeped in Lockean empiricism as their opponents. It was in Germany that disagreement with the excesses of empiricism led to a more fundamental rejection of the entire approach. At first, British mental philosophy was quite popular among German writers, but in the latter part of the eighteenth century that changed (Dessoir, 1902). Two kinds of knowledge came to be more and more sharply distinguished: one based on the distanced, dispassionate, observation of nature encouraged by science, the other typified by the more subjective, involved, way of experiencing the world expressed in the new literary and artistic style of Romanticism. As this distinction crystallized, the terms *Empfindung* (sensation) and *Gefühl* (feeling) took on their modern psychological meaning. In the nineteenth century an analogous process occurred in English. Prior to this, 'feeling' had referred to any mental state (see note 5); now it took on the subjective colouring which placed it in the proximity of 'emotion'.

Romanticism entailed a further reorganization of the categories of mental activity. In the classical, rationalist, scheme the salient distinction was between clear and distinct ideas and unclear, confused, ideas. The latter marked what would later be called 'emotional' experiences, but the distinction was based on their *inferiority*, not on their difference in kind. Empiricism devalued this distinction, but it also emphasized the privacy of experience and encouraged self-observation. The need to combine this emphasis with the modern respect for dispassionate scientific observation eventually led to the distinction between feeling and sensation. The latter provided the supposed basis for 'objective' knowledge, the former for 'subjective' experience.¹⁰ Since the nineteenth century, the psychology of sensation and perception and the psychology of feeling and emotion have therefore been constituted as separate fields.

Notes

1. Graham Richards has presented the only extensive discussion of this issue in the literature. He sums up as follows: 'no single tap-root of Psychology is present in the seventeenth century, but there is a range of one-off, discrete anticipations of specific realms of Psychological enquiry, both within and outside the texts in the orthodox canon. These nearly always failed to initiate continuous traditions of enquiry and contributed little to the development of the modern enquiries they anticipated' (Richards, 1992: 92).

2. The most prominent examples of such textbooks are those by Bain (1977) and by Spencer (1871). What was new in them was the latter's evolutionary perspective and the

former's recourse to physiology. In their purely psychological conceptionalization they continued along the tracks laid down by earlier British empiricists.

3. Bishop Berkeley and Mandeville engaged in a public polemic. The links between Mandeville and Adam Smith have often been noted and are extensively explored in Dumont (1977).

4. Butler did not invent this terminology. There was by this time quite a history of discourse about interests as 'countervailing passions' linked to the beneficial effects of capitalist economic activity (Hirschman, 1977). The British eighteenth-century moralists systematized this discourse and elaborated its quasi-psychological implications more thoroughly than their predecessors.

5. At this stage, the term 'feeling' still functions as a synonym for 'state of mind', so that sensations and perceptions are also categorized as feelings. The liaison between feeling and emotion came later. This is discussed in the section, 'A new sense of self' (pp. 46-9).

6. Hume's determinism was no idiosyncrasy. Quite independently, David Hartley was working on another deterministic account of human conduct at the same time, though he only published the final version ten years after Hume's account had appeared (Hartley, 1749). Unlike Hume, Hartley provided a theological rationale for his determinism. This was however ignored by his rather influential nineteenth-century followers, who included James Mill and W.B. Carpenter. In psychology, the legacy of eighteenth-century determinism and mechanism was first preserved in its specifically Hartleyan rather than its Humean form. But in the long run, the influence of Hume, a major philosopher, was much greater.

7. This is not to be confused with earlier doctrines that had proclaimed the ultimate selfishness of human striving. The point here is not the selfishness of goals but the inevitable privacy of their origins. Those eighteenth-century descendants of Locke who believed in a 'moral sense' could recognize unselfish goals; what had become unthinkable for them were goals that did not have a private origin.

8. Locke was clearly indebted to Descartes' derivation of personal existence from personal thought - 'I think, therefore I am'. From a philosophical perspective, Descartes' point was more fundamental, but in the history of modern psychology it is Locke's formulation of questions and answers about the self that marks the beginning of the empiricist discourse that has dominated this field. By contrast, Descartes' commitment to a metaphysical soul substance and a rational will erected insuperable obstacles to the development of anything like modern Psychology.

9. When the English word 'self' first appeared as a noun, around 1300, it had the negative connotations derived from a long tradition of seeing the individual primarily as a sinner. The *Oxford English Dictionary* (OED) (1989, XIV: 906) quotes an early example: 'Oure awn self we sal deny, and folow oure lord god al-myghty.' This opposition between the self as an incarnation of wickedness and divine goodness survives for several centuries. An example from 1680 declares that 'Self is the great Anti-Christ and Anti-God in the world' (OED, 1989, XIV: 907). But by then there was also a counter-current that had announced itself in the appearance of numerous new 'self' compounds in the English language. Many of these carried positive rather than negative connotations, as in *self-made* (1615), *self-interest* (1649), and *self-confidence* (1653).

10. Philosophically, the seeds of the distinction can be traced to the differentiation of 'primary and secondary qualities' which Locke had adopted. Historically, many other factors enter into the picture.

THE PHYSIOLOGICAL BACKGROUND

Psychology and physiology

If a significant number of the fundamental categories of twentieth-century Psychology had their source in empiricist mental philosophy, could one say that this Psychology was a kind of continuation of empiricist philosophy by other means? That would be going too far. First of all, these 'other means' – experimental and statistical technologies – were never mere passive instruments, but played a crucial role in reshaping the conceptual landscape of the discipline. Secondly, modern Psychology relied on the older sciences for more than its technology. Some of its most basic categories had a biological origin. There was nothing arbitrary about the title of the first major textbook of the new science: *Principles of Physiological Psychology* (Wundt, 1874). The topics, the methodology and the conceptual apparatus were all to be found in the physiology of the time. Strong traces of this legacy were still evident a century later.

The dependence of early experimental psychology on previous work in physiology has always been obvious. What has been much less obvious is the appropriate time frame for assessing the nature of this dependence. It is clear that virtually all of the work in the first psychological laboratories stood in a direct line of descent from similar work in mid-nineteenth-century physiological laboratories. One thinks of work on vision, touch and hearing, on reaction time measurement, on the recording of physiological reactions, and so on. However, that is not all there is to the story. The conceptual link between physiological and psychological topics goes back rather further than this practical link. In fact, the boundary between physiology and psychology was not always drawn as sharply as it was in the latter part of the nineteenth century. By that time, physiology had finally embraced a consistently mechanistic approach. Henceforth it would limit itself to the investigation of somatic functions in a purely physicalistic framework.¹ That project was extremely successful, but it did entail the jettisoning of that part of its older mandate which had extended to psychological issues. In a manner of speaking, the newly autonomous physiological psychology had been spat out by nineteenth-century physiology.